2.1 Political Parties Form

You've probably seen the ads. "Vote for me! Don't vote for" — whomever. The candidates are usually from different political parties. You can thank (or blame) Hamilton and Jefferson for laying the groundwork for such parties.

MAIN IDEA Leaders formed political parties to promote their ideas, forming the basis of the modern American political system.

TAKING SIDES

During the 1790s, many congressional representatives sided with either Hamilton, who fought for a strong central government, or Jefferson, who feared the power such a government could wield. Eventually, the two sides formed two political parties—the **Federalist Party** and the **Democratic-Republican Party**. The Federalists backed Hamilton. The Democratic-Republicans sided more with Jefferson.

The Constitution made no provision for political parties, but it did not prohibit them. Still, the idea of divided political parties shocked the older leaders of the Revolutionary era. Washington warned against their "baneful [harmful] effects." If they were to play any role at all, he said, they needed to be kept in check. But the process was now in motion. Political parties had established themselves as a powerful force, and sides had been taken.

FACING OFF

On one side stood the Federalist Party, whose **power base**, or area of biggest influence, was in New England and the Middle Atlantic states. John Adams, Washington's vice president, joined the Federalists. They favored commercial development, a National Bank, the development of infrastructure to build canals, roads, and schools through land grants, and high tariffs to spur manufacturing. They also believed in a **loose interpretation** of the Constitution—one that gave broad powers to Congress and the president. Federalists were more likely than their opponents to be critical of slavery and so gained the allegiance of free African Americans in both the North and the South. Because their power base lay in the Northeast, many Federalists didn't back the idea of western expansion and sometimes supported the rights of Native Americans.

On the other side was the Democratic-Republican Party, whose power base was in the South and the West. The party included many former antifederalists. Like Jefferson, the Democratic-Republicans believed in a **strict interpretation** of the Constitution—one that strictly followed the document and honored the rights of states over federal power. They opposed too much federal support for manufacturing and commerce. With its southern backing, the party rejected efforts to abolish slavery. Because it favored westward expansion and had little sympathy for the rights of Native Americans, the party also had the support of westerners on the frontier. The fundamental tension created by the development of a two-party system continues to influence American politics today.

In addition to these internal divisions within the government, the United States had to confront more fundamental challenges to its authority and legitimacy. Trouble was brewing in the Northwest Territory and abroad.

HISTORICAL THINKING

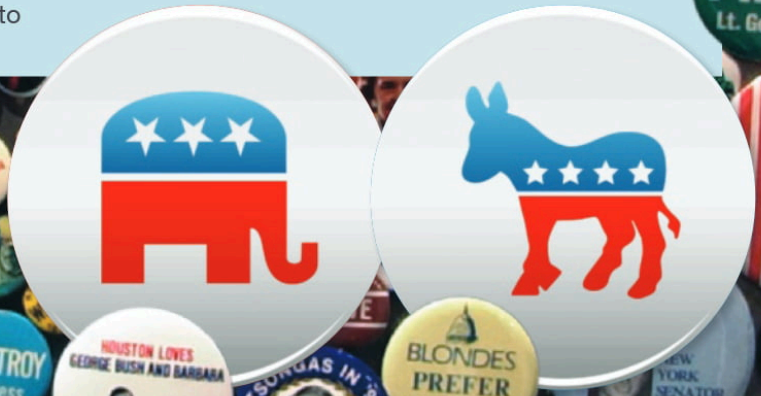
1. **READING CHECK** What regions of the United States supported each party, and why?
2. **IDENTIFY PROBLEMS AND SOLUTIONS** What problems might either a loose or strict interpretation of the Constitution create or solve?
3. **EVALUATE** What are the advantages and disadvantages of political parties?

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Two-Party System

Although the parties have changed and shifted over the years, the United States still has two major political parties: the Democrats and the Republicans. A two-party system is relatively unique in the world. Some countries have only one party, while others have many. The symbols of each U.S. party are shown below: a donkey for the Democrats and an elephant for the Republicans. Neither modern party aligns closely with the political ideas of the Federalists or the Democratic-Republicans. However, like the parties in the 1790s, the parties today have regional characteristics. The Republicans tend to be stronger in the South and the West, and the Democrats stronger on the coasts, the Northeast, and the upper Midwest.

The campaign buttons shown are from the second half of the 20th century. Remember, though, that supporters purchased buttons honoring George Washington at his inauguration. In the 1840 election, people wore campaign buttons sewn on clothing. Pins were added around 1860, along with the first photograph to appear on a campaign button—a picture of Abraham Lincoln.



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